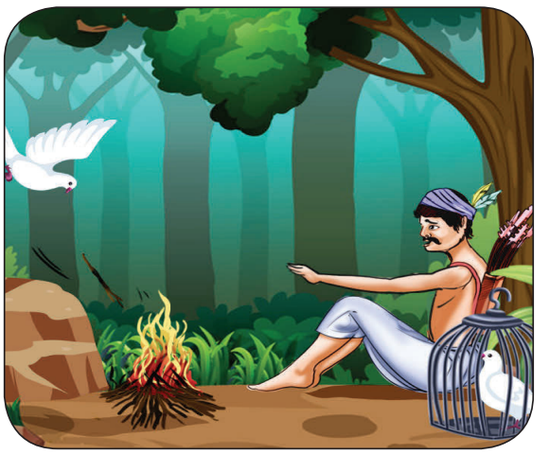


It started to rain heavily, just then, the hen-pigeon saw a bird catcher coming near the tree. In the cage, he had the cock-pigeon. It was unconscious. Fear gripped the hen pigeon. Was it her friend? The bird catcher neared the tree. She had to hide, but she also wanted to have a closer look, to see if it was her friend. She flew down to the lowest branch. "Oh no! It is him. What shall I do now? I have to help my friend." worried the hen-pigeon. The sky thundered and the bird catcher took cover under her tree. "Looks like I have to wait till the rain stops" said the bird catcher.

Soon it stopped raining, the bird catcher wanted to leave. But it was too dark and late in the night. "I will camp here for the night and leave in the morning." he thought. It was a wet and cold night and he wanted to start a fire to keep himself warm. He could not find any dry twigs. The pigeon in the cage woke up and tried to fly only for his wings to hit the cage.

The hen-pigeon started to cry. Her friend said, "Do not feel sad dear. We have a guest now. The man is shivering and hungry. He needs your help." The pigeon flew from the tree in search of dry twigs. She got two or three twigs at a time and made a big heap of dry twigs. She got flintstones for the bird catcher to start the fire. The bird catcher was surprised by the hen-pigeon. He made fire. "You are my guest. I have no food to give you. I will jump into this fire so that you can eat me. The bird catcher was overwhelmed by the hospitality of the pigeon. He caught the hen pigeon and stopped her from jumping into the fire. "Oh, kind bird! What do you want? I will help you in any way I can." said the bird catcher. "Please set my friend free. My life will be meaningless without him." replied the pigeon.



He opened the cage and set the pigeon free. "I was cruel and selfish. I will never trap any bird again" said the bird catcher. He stayed the night there. In the morning, the pigeons got him nuts, fruits and seeds to eat. The bird catcher thanked the pigeons and walked away.

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